

THE PLAN OF SALVATION

BRL Sermons — Level 3 Sermon Archive

Sermon Type: Topical / Expository-Topical

Primary Texts: Matthew 28:18–20; Mark 16:15–16; Luke 24:46–47; Acts 2:36–42

Supporting Corpus: Conversion Accounts in Acts; Romans 6:1–18

Theme: God's revealed response to the gospel of Jesus Christ

Tagline: *Through Context. For the Church. For His Glory.*

SERMON PROPOSITION

God has revealed through the gospel how sinners come to Christ: they **hear** His Word, **believe** in Jesus Christ, **repent** of sin, **confess** Christ, are **baptized into Christ**, and thereafter live in **faithful obedience** to Him.

Sermon Refrain

Hear His Word.

Believe His Son.

Repent of Sin.

Confess His Name.

Be Baptized into Christ.

Obey Him Faithfully.

I. FOUNDATIONAL EXEGESIS — SALVATION BEGINS WITH GOD, NOT MAN

Before examining what man must do in response to the gospel, the order of salvation must be established correctly.

The biblical plan of salvation does **not** begin with:

“Hear, believe, repent, confess, and be baptized.”

It begins with **God**.

Man did not devise salvation. Man did not initiate reconciliation. Man did not provide the sacrifice. Man does not determine the conditions upon which God offers forgiveness.

God acted first.

John 3:16 declares:

“God so loved the world, that he gave his only begotten Son.”

1. **Context — DC:** Jesus explains God's saving love and the giving of His Son in His discussion concerning new birth, belief, condemnation, and eternal life.
2. **Authority — I:** Salvation originates in God's initiative; the Son is God's provision rather than man's achievement.

Romans 5:8 explains:

“while we were yet sinners, Christ died for us.”

1. **Context — DC:** Paul contrasts man's sinful condition with God's demonstrated love through Christ's death.
2. **Authority — I:** Christ's saving death occurred while humanity was sinful and therefore cannot be understood as something sinners first earned or initiated.

Ephesians 2:4–5 begins with God's mercy:

“God, who is rich in mercy, for his great love wherewith he loved us...”

1. **Context — DC:** Paul contrasts man's former spiritual death in sin with God's merciful action in making sinners alive with Christ.
2. **Authority — I:** Spiritual life originates in God's mercy and grace rather than human merit.

Therefore, the biblical order is:

God loved.

Christ died.

The gospel was revealed.

The gospel is preached.

Man responds.

God saves.

The Christian faithfully follows Christ.

This distinction is essential.

The six elements examined in this sermon are **not six human works by which man earns salvation**. They describe man's divinely commanded response to the saving work God has already accomplished through Jesus Christ.

Salvation remains entirely dependent upon God's grace.

Ephesians 2:8–9 — “For by grace are ye saved through faith...”

1. **Context — DC:** Paul explains the divine basis of the salvation described in Ephesians 2:1–7.
2. **Authority — I:** Salvation is God's gift and cannot be treated as wages earned by human works.

Yet biblical grace never eliminates man's responsibility to respond to God.

Titus 2:11–12 demonstrates that grace itself teaches:

“the grace of God that bringeth salvation... Teaching us...”

1. **Context — DC:** Paul explains the practical effect of God's saving grace upon the lives of those who receive it.
2. **Authority — I:** Saving grace instructs its recipients to reject ungodliness and live obediently; grace and obedient living therefore cannot legitimately be placed in opposition.

Grace does not remove obedience.

Grace **instructs obedience**.

II. THE GREAT COMMISSION ESTABLISHES THE GOSPEL PATTERN

Before studying individual conversion accounts in Acts, the commission of Christ establishes what the apostles were commanded to preach.

Three Gospel accounts are especially significant.

A. Matthew 28:18–20 — Make Disciples, Baptize, Teach

Jesus declared:

“All power is given unto me in heaven and in earth.”

1. **Context — DC:** The risen Christ commissions His apostles immediately before they carry the gospel to the nations.
2. **Authority — C:** The commands that follow rest upon Christ's universal authority.

The command begins with Christ's authority.

The apostles were therefore not authorized to invent their own evangelistic message.

Jesus commanded:

“Go ye therefore, and teach all nations, baptizing them...”

1. **Context — DC:** Christ defines the apostles' disciple-making mission.
2. **Authority — C:** The apostles are commanded to make disciples among the nations and baptize them.
3. **Authority — I:** Baptism belongs within the disciple-making commission established by Christ rather than being a later human addition.

The progression is significant:

Christ possesses authority → disciples are made → disciples are baptized → baptized disciples are taught continued obedience.

Jesus then commanded:

“Teaching them to observe all things whatsoever I have commanded you.”

1. **Context — DC:** Christ describes the continuing instruction of those made disciples and baptized.
2. **Authority — C:** Disciples must be taught to observe Christ's commands.
3. **Authority — I:** Baptism cannot represent the end of discipleship because Christ expressly requires continued teaching and obedience afterward.

This immediately prevents baptism from becoming the conclusion of discipleship.

Baptism marks entrance into a life of submission to Christ.

The disciple must thereafter be taught to **observe** Christ's commands.

Thus Matthew's commission already contains the principle represented by the sixth sermon point:

Obedience continues after baptism.

B. Mark 16:15–16 — Gospel, Faith, Baptism, Salvation

Jesus commanded:

“Go ye into all the world, and preach the gospel to every creature.”

1. **Context — DC:** The risen Christ commissions gospel proclamation to the world.
2. **Authority — C:** The gospel is commanded to be preached universally.

3. **Authority — I:** If the gospel must be preached before it can be believed, hearing necessarily precedes biblical faith.

The gospel must first be communicated.

This necessarily establishes **hearing**.

Then:

“He that believeth and is baptized shall be saved.”

1. **Context — DC:** Christ identifies the response to the gospel just commanded to be preached.
2. **Authority — C:** Belief and baptism are stated by Christ in connection with the promise of salvation.
3. **Authority — I:** In Christ's positive statement, belief and baptism precede the stated promise, “shall be saved.”

The grammatical progression is straightforward:

Gospel preached → Gospel believed → Believer baptized → Salvation promised.

The text does not present baptism independently of faith.

Neither does it present faith independently of baptism in the positive statement.

Christ joins the believing and baptized person with the promise:

“shall be saved.”

The second clause states:

“but he that believeth not shall be damned.”

1. **Context — DC:** Christ contrasts the positive response to the gospel with rejection through unbelief.
2. **Authority — I:** Unbelief prevents every subsequent act of faithful response because one who rejects the gospel will not submit to what the gospel commands.

Unbelief alone is sufficient to condemn because the unbeliever will never proceed obediently in response to the gospel he rejects.

C. Luke 24:46–47 — Christ's Death, Resurrection, Repentance, Forgiveness

Jesus explained that Scripture foretold:

“that Christ should suffer, and to rise from the dead the third day.”

1. **Context — DC:** The risen Jesus explains the scriptural necessity of His suffering and resurrection to His disciples.
2. **Authority — I:** The apostles' saving message is grounded in the accomplished death and resurrection of Christ rather than in a humanly devised system.

This is the historical foundation of the gospel.

Then:

“repentance and remission of sins should be preached in his name among all nations, beginning at Jerusalem.”

1. **Context — DC:** Christ defines what is to be proclaimed in response to His death and resurrection.
2. **Authority — C:** Repentance and remission of sins are to be preached in Christ's name among all nations.
3. **Authority — I:** Because Christ specifies Jerusalem as the beginning point, the Jerusalem preaching recorded in Acts must be examined as the historical implementation of this commission.

Luke therefore connects:

Christ's death → Christ's resurrection → preaching → repentance → remission of sins.

The geographical statement is equally important:

“beginning at Jerusalem.”

1. **Context — DC:** Jerusalem is explicitly designated as the geographical starting point of the gospel proclamation.
2. **Context — RC:** Acts 1–2 records the apostles remaining in Jerusalem and then publicly preaching the risen Christ there.
3. **Authority — I:** Acts 2 supplies inspired historical evidence for how the apostles understood and carried out Christ's command in Luke 24.

Luke's Gospel ends with the promise that this message will begin at Jerusalem.

Acts opens with the apostles waiting in Jerusalem.

Then Acts 2 records the gospel being preached publicly in Jerusalem.

This makes Acts 2 not an isolated proof text but the historical fulfillment of Christ's commission.

III. ACTS 2 — THE COMMISSION PUT INTO PRACTICE

Acts 2 provides the first major public gospel sermon following Christ's resurrection and ascension.

Peter does not begin by giving his audience a list of steps.

He **preaches Christ**.

That distinction should shape the sermon.

A. They Heard the Gospel

Peter proclaimed Jesus' life, miracles, crucifixion, resurrection, exaltation, and lordship.

Acts 2:22:

“Jesus of Nazareth, a man approved of God...”

1. **Context — DC:** Peter identifies Jesus to the Jerusalem audience and begins establishing God's testimony concerning Him.
2. **Authority — I:** Gospel preaching requires the hearer to be confronted with the identity and divine authentication of Jesus.

Acts 2:23:

“ye have taken, and by wicked hands have crucified and slain.”

1. **Context — DC:** Peter confronts his hearers with their relationship to the crucifixion of Jesus.
2. **Authority — I:** The gospel exposes human sin and guilt before presenting the required response.

Acts 2:24:

“Whom God hath raised up...”

1. **Context — DC:** Peter proclaims God's reversal of man's rejection of Jesus through the resurrection.

2. **Authority — I:** The resurrection is part of the historical content upon which the hearers' faith must rest.

Acts 2:32:

“This Jesus hath God raised up...”

1. **Context — DC:** Peter presents the apostles as witnesses to Jesus' resurrection.
2. **Authority — E:** The apostolic eyewitness testimony provides inspired testimony to the resurrection proclaimed.

Acts 2:36 reaches Peter's conclusion:

“God hath made that same Jesus... both Lord and Christ.”

1. **Context — DC:** Peter concludes the argument of his Pentecost sermon by identifying the crucified and risen Jesus as Lord and Christ.
2. **Authority — I:** The hearers must respond to Jesus according to His true identity and authority.

The plan of salvation therefore begins evangelistically not by preaching baptism, but by **preaching Jesus**.

There can be no biblical faith without a biblical message about Christ.

B. They Believed What They Heard

Acts 2:37 states:

“when they heard this, they were pricked in their heart.”

1. **Context — DC:** The statement records the immediate response of Peter's audience to the gospel just preached.
2. **Authority — E:** The Pentecost hearers provide an inspired example of gospel proclamation producing conviction.
3. **Authority — I:** Their subsequent question demonstrates acceptance of Peter's message sufficiently to seek the required response.

The gospel produced conviction.

They now recognized the truth concerning the One whom they had crucified.

Their question demonstrates their belief:

“Men and brethren, what shall we do?”

1. **Context — DC:** The convicted hearers ask the apostles what response their newly recognized condition requires.
2. **Authority — E:** They provide an example of convicted hearers seeking God's required response.
3. **Authority — I:** Because their question arises directly from accepting Peter's claims about Jesus, Peter's answer in verse 38 must be interpreted as an answer to convicted gospel hearers.

They did not ask whether Peter's message was true.

They asked what they must now **do because it was true**.

C. They Were Commanded to Repent

Peter answered:

“Repent...”

1. **Context — DC:** Peter directly answers the convicted hearers' question, “What shall we do?”
2. **Authority — C:** Repentance is explicitly commanded.

The Greek verb **μετανοέω** (*metanoeō*) concerns a change of mind resulting in a changed direction.

Biblical repentance is therefore more than sorrow.

Paul distinguishes the two in 2 Corinthians 7:10:

“godly sorrow worketh repentance...”

1. **Context — RC:** Paul's teaching distinguishes godly sorrow from the repentance that sorrow produces.
2. **Authority — I:** Because sorrow “worketh repentance,” sorrow and repentance cannot be treated as identical.

Sorrow may produce repentance, but sorrow itself is not repentance.

The Jerusalem hearers had been convicted concerning Christ.

Now their relationship toward sin and toward Christ had to change.

D. They Were Commanded to Be Baptized

Peter continued:

“and be baptized every one of you in the name of Jesus Christ for the remission of sins...”

1. **Context — DC:** Baptism occurs within Peter's direct inspired answer to “What shall we do?”
2. **Authority — C:** Peter explicitly commands every one of the convicted hearers to be baptized.
3. **Context — RC:** Luke 24:47 had announced that repentance and remission of sins would be preached in Christ's name beginning at Jerusalem.
4. **Authority — I:** Acts 2:38 is the Jerusalem proclamation anticipated by Luke 24:47 and therefore demonstrates the apostles' inspired implementation of Christ's commission.

Baptism was not presented as an optional ceremony to be performed after salvation.

It appears directly within Peter's answer to:

“What shall we do?”

The purpose stated in the text is:

“for the remission of sins.”

The phrase parallels Christ's earlier declaration in Luke 24:47 that:

“repentance and remission of sins should be preached...”

Luke 24 promises the preaching.

Acts 2 records its fulfillment.

E. They Obeyed the Gospel

Acts 2:41 records:

“Then they that gladly received his word were baptized.”

1. **Context — DC:** Luke records the response of those who accepted Peter's Pentecost preaching.
2. **Authority — E:** Those who received the apostolic word provide an inspired example of immediate baptism.
3. **Authority — I:** Receiving the apostolic message included submitting to the baptism commanded in verse 38.

Notice Luke's description.

They **received his word**.

The acceptance of the message produced obedient action.

Approximately three thousand were baptized.

But their story does not end in Acts 2:41.

The next verse is indispensable.

Acts 2:42:

“And they continued stedfastly...”

1. **Context — DC:** Luke describes the life of the newly baptized disciples immediately following their conversion.
2. **Authority — E:** The first Jerusalem Christians provide an inspired example of continued doctrine, fellowship, breaking of bread, and prayers after baptism.
3. **Authority — I:** Conversion initiates continuing discipleship rather than terminating man's responsibility to Christ.

Thus the first major conversion account provides the same larger pattern:

They heard.

They believed.

They repented.

They were baptized.

They continued.

Christian conversion produced Christian living.

IV. THE CONVERSION ACCOUNTS OF ACTS — ONE GOSPEL, DIFFERENT EMPHASES

No single conversion narrative repeats every element using identical terminology.

This is exactly what should be expected from historical narrative.

The question is not:

“Does every conversion account repeat the same formula?”

The proper question is:

“What complete pattern emerges when all inspired conversion accounts are examined together?”

This is where DC/RC/TC becomes particularly important.

One passage must not be isolated from the total testimony of Scripture.

A. Pentecost — Acts 2:14–42

Heard: Peter preached Christ.

Believed: They were “pricked in their heart.”

Repented: Explicitly commanded.

Confession: Not explicitly recorded.

Baptism: Explicitly commanded and performed.

Continued obedience: Explicitly recorded.

1. **Context — DC:** The complete narrative records the preaching, conviction, commanded response, baptism, and subsequent life of the Jerusalem converts.
2. **Authority — C:** Repentance and baptism are explicitly commanded.
3. **Authority — E:** Those receiving the word are baptized and continue steadfastly.
4. **Authority — I:** Elements not expressly repeated in every conversion narrative must be interpreted in harmony with the complete apostolic pattern rather than assumed absent.

B. The Samaritans — Acts 8:5–13

Philip:

“preached Christ unto them.”

Acts 8:12 states:

“when they believed Philip preaching the things concerning the kingdom of God, and the name of Jesus Christ, they were baptized...”

1. **Context — DC:** Luke describes the Samaritans' response to Philip's preaching of Christ and the kingdom.
2. **Authority — E:** Believing men and women provide an inspired example of baptism following reception of the gospel.
3. **Authority — I:** Apostolic-era evangelism joined preaching Christ and the kingdom with instruction that resulted in baptism.

Pattern:

Preaching → Hearing → Believing → Baptism

Both:

“men and women”

were baptized.

C. The Ethiopian Eunuch — Acts 8:26–40

Philip begins with Isaiah and:

“preached unto him Jesus.”

As they traveled, the eunuch asked:

“See, here is water; what doth hinder me to be baptized?”

1. **Context — DC:** The baptism question arises within Philip's evangelistic explanation of Jesus from Isaiah.
2. **Authority — E:** The eunuch provides an inspired example of requesting and receiving baptism upon hearing Jesus preached.
3. **Authority — I:** Because the request for baptism results from Philip's preaching of Jesus, preaching Jesus necessarily included sufficient instruction for the hearer to understand his need for baptism.

This creates an important inference.

If Philip merely “preached Jesus,” yet the hearer subsequently requested baptism, then **preaching Jesus necessarily included teaching concerning baptism.**

Baptism is therefore not a distraction from preaching Christ.

Biblically taught, baptism is part of preaching Christ.

The eunuch stopped the chariot.

They entered the water.

Philip baptized him.

Then:

“he went on his way rejoicing.”

1. **Context — DC:** The eunuch's rejoicing follows his reception of the gospel and baptism.
 2. **Authority — E:** The conversion provides an inspired example of immediate obedient response followed by rejoicing.
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D. Saul of Tarsus — Acts 9; 22; 26

Saul encountered the risen Christ and unquestionably came to believe that Jesus was Lord.

Yet Saul was instructed:

“Arise, and go into the city, and it shall be told thee what thou must do.”

1. **Context — DC:** Jesus directs the believing and humbled Saul to await further instruction concerning what he must do.
2. **Authority — C:** Saul is commanded to enter the city and receive further instruction.
3. **Authority — I:** Saul's encounter and belief did not eliminate the necessity of the response that would subsequently be revealed to him.

Three days later Ananias told him:

“And now why tarriest thou? arise, and be baptized, and wash away thy sins, calling on the name of the Lord.”

— Acts 22:16

1. **Context — DC:** Paul recounts Ananias' instruction concerning his required response after encountering Christ.

2. **Authority — C:** Saul is explicitly commanded to arise and be baptized.
3. **Authority — I:** The language “wash away thy sins” places baptism within Saul's conversion response rather than treating it merely as a later public testimony.

Saul had:

Encountered Christ.

Believed Christ.

Repented in anguish and fasting.

Acknowledged Christ's authority.

Yet Ananias still instructed him to:

“be baptized, and wash away thy sins.”

This account strongly challenges the idea that inward belief alone had completed Saul's conversion before Ananias arrived.

E. Cornelius — Acts 10–11

Cornelius presents a particularly important case requiring careful treatment.

He was:

“a devout man, and one that feared God.”

He prayed and gave alms.

Yet he still needed to hear the saving gospel.

According to Acts 11:14, Peter would:

“tell thee words, whereby thou and all thy house shall be saved.”

1. **Context — RC:** Acts 11 supplies Peter's inspired retrospective explanation of the events recorded in Acts 10.
2. **Authority — I:** Cornelius' devotion, prayers, and alms did not remove his need to hear the saving message Peter was commissioned to bring.

Peter preached Christ.

The Holy Spirit fell upon the Gentile hearers, demonstrating God's acceptance of Gentiles and convincing the Jewish witnesses.

Peter then asked:

“Can any man forbid water...?”

And:

“he commanded them to be baptized in the name of the Lord.”

1. **Context — DC:** Peter responds to the miraculous evidence that God had admitted Gentiles to gospel privileges.
2. **Authority — C:** Cornelius and his household are explicitly commanded to be baptized.
3. **Authority — I:** The miraculous reception of the Holy Spirit did not cancel baptism, because Peter commanded baptism after the Spirit had fallen upon them.

The miraculous outpouring did not eliminate baptism.

Instead, Peter immediately **commanded baptism**.

F. Lydia — Acts 16:13–15

Luke records:

“whose heart the Lord opened, that she attended unto the things which were spoken of Paul.”

1. **Context — DC:** Lydia hears Paul's gospel teaching and responds attentively to it.
2. **Authority — E:** Lydia provides an inspired example of receptive hearing followed by baptism.
3. **Authority — I:** The Lord's opening of Lydia's heart did not bypass the preached Word or her obedient response to it.

She heard.

She responded to Paul's teaching.

Then:

“she was baptized, and her household.”

Again:

Word preached → receptive heart → baptism

G. The Philippian Jailer — Acts 16:25–34

The jailer asked:

“Sirs, what must I do to be saved?”

Paul and Silas answered:

“Believe on the Lord Jesus Christ...”

1. **Context — DC:** Paul first identifies faith in Christ as essential in response to the jailer's salvation question.
2. **Authority — C:** The jailer is commanded to believe on the Lord Jesus Christ.

If verse 31 is isolated, the account appears to end there.

But the narrative continues.

Verse 32:

“they spake unto him the word of the Lord.”

1. **Context — DC:** Paul and Silas explain the gospel to the man they have just commanded to believe.
2. **Authority — E:** The narrative demonstrates that the command to believe is followed by instruction providing the content of that faith.
3. **Authority — I:** Biblical belief cannot precede knowledge of its gospel content; therefore verse 31 cannot legitimately be isolated from verse 32.

He could not believe a gospel he had not yet heard explained.

After hearing the Word:

“he took them the same hour of the night, and washed their stripes; and was baptized...”

1. **Context — DC:** Baptism follows immediately upon the jailer's hearing of the Word.
2. **Authority — E:** The jailer provides an inspired example of baptism in the same hour in which the gospel was taught.
3. **Authority — I:** The immediacy of baptism indicates that it belonged to the conversion response rather than being postponed as a later church ceremony.

Then the text describes him as:

“believing in God with all his house.”

The full narrative therefore presents:

Question → Christ identified as object of faith → Word preached → response → immediate baptism → rejoicing believer.

H. The Corinthians — Acts 18:8

Luke summarizes their conversions concisely:

“many of the Corinthians hearing believed, and were baptized.”

1. **Context — DC:** Luke summarizes the Corinthians' response to gospel preaching.
2. **Authority — E:** The Corinthians provide an inspired example of the sequence hearing, believing, and baptism.
3. **Authority — I:** Hearing, faith, and baptism function together within the conversion narrative rather than as unrelated religious events.

Few passages state the sequence more simply.

Hearing → Believing → Baptism

I. The Ephesians — Acts 19:1–7

These individuals had previously received John's baptism.

After Paul explained Christ:

“When they heard this, they were baptized in the name of the Lord Jesus.”

1. **Context — DC:** Paul corrects disciples whose prior baptism belonged to John's preparatory ministry rather than baptism into the Lord Jesus.
2. **Authority — E:** The Ephesians provide an inspired example of receiving proper baptism after recognizing the insufficiency of their former baptism.
3. **Authority — I:** The mere act of immersion is not sufficient; baptism must correspond to the gospel revelation and relationship to Christ under which it is administered.

This establishes another important principle:

Not every baptism is necessarily biblical baptism.

Correct baptism requires the proper gospel understanding and relationship to Christ.

V. SYNTHESIS OF THE ACTS CONVERSION ACCOUNTS

When the accounts are considered together rather than isolated, a recognizable pattern emerges.

Element	Representative Texts
Hear	Acts 2:37; 8:5; 16:14; 18:8
Believe	Acts 8:12; 16:31–34; 18:8
Repent	Acts 2:38; 3:19; 17:30
Confess Christ	Acts 8:35–38; cf. Romans 10:9–10
Be Baptized	Acts 2:38, 41; 8:12, 38; 10:48; 16:15, 33; 18:8; 19:5; 22:16

Continue Faithfully Acts 2:42; 14:22; cf. Revelation 2:10

1. **Context — TC:** The collective conversion narratives in Acts establish the recurring apostolic pattern rather than requiring any single account to restate every element.
2. **Authority — C:** Faith, repentance, and baptism appear as explicit commands within the apostolic record.
3. **Authority — E:** Multiple inspired conversion accounts demonstrate hearing, believing, baptism, and continued discipleship.
4. **Authority — I:** The complete conversion doctrine must be constructed from the combined inspired testimony rather than by isolating whichever single account contains the fewest stated elements.

The inspired record therefore does not present six disconnected requirements.

It presents **one integrated response to one gospel**.

VI. SERMON MAIN POINT 1 — HEAR HIS WORD

A. Faith Requires Revelation

Romans 10:17:

“faith cometh by hearing, and hearing by the word of God.”

1. **Context — DC:** Paul explains the relationship between proclamation, hearing, and faith.
2. **Authority — I:** Biblical faith depends upon hearing God's revealed message.

Saving faith cannot arise independently of revelation.

Romans 10:14 asks:

“how shall they believe in him of whom they have not heard?”

1. **Context — DC:** Paul reasons backward from calling upon the Lord to belief, hearing, preaching, and sending.
2. **Authority — I:** Belief necessarily depends upon prior hearing of the message concerning Christ.

Therefore:

No gospel → no hearing.

No hearing → no biblical faith.

The gospel provides the content of saving faith.

B. What Must Be Heard?

Not merely religious information.

The message centers upon Christ.

1 Corinthians 15:3–4 summarizes:

“Christ died for our sins...”

and:

“he rose again the third day...”

1. **Context — DC:** Paul reminds the Corinthians of the gospel he preached and they received.
2. **Authority — I:** The historical death, burial, and resurrection of Christ form the central content of the gospel to which man responds.

The plan of salvation therefore must never replace the **Man of salvation**.

We do not merely preach:

Hear. Believe. Repent. Confess. Be baptized.

We preach:

Jesus died.

Jesus was buried.

Jesus arose.

Jesus reigns.

Therefore, what will you do with Jesus?

VII. SERMON MAIN POINT 2 — BELIEVE HIS SON

John 8:24:

“if ye believe not that I am he, ye shall die in your sins.”

1. **Context — DC:** Jesus warns unbelieving hearers concerning the consequence of rejecting His identity.
2. **Authority — C:** Faith in Jesus is presented as necessary to avoid dying in sin.

Biblical faith is not mere intellectual acknowledgment.

The Greek πιστεύω (*pisteuō*) carries the concept of believing, trusting, placing confidence in.

James 2:19 warns:

“the devils also believe, and tremble.”

1. **Context — RC:** James distinguishes living faith from a bare intellectual belief that produces no obedient action.
2. **Authority — I:** Mere acknowledgment of truth cannot exhaust the biblical meaning of saving faith.

Therefore saving faith cannot mean mere acknowledgment of God's existence.

Biblical faith moves.

Hebrews 11 repeatedly demonstrates this pattern:

By faith Abel offered.

By faith Noah prepared.

By faith Abraham obeyed.

1. **Context — RC:** Hebrews 11 illustrates the character of faith through obedient actions of faithful people.
2. **Authority — E:** Abel, Noah, and Abraham provide inspired examples of faith expressing itself through obedient action.
3. **Authority — I:** Biblical faith is not presented as passive mental assent but as trust that acts upon God's Word.

Faith that refuses obedience contradicts the biblical character of faith.

VIII. SERMON MAIN POINT 3 — REPENT OF SIN

Luke 13:3:

“except ye repent, ye shall all likewise perish.”

1. **Context — DC:** Jesus corrects assumptions concerning others' suffering and turns the warning toward His hearers' own need for repentance.
2. **Authority — C:** Repentance is explicitly required to avoid perishing.

Acts 17:30:

“God... commandeth all men every where to repent.”

1. **Context — DC:** Paul calls pagan Athenians away from idolatrous ignorance in view of God's coming judgment through Christ.
2. **Authority — C:** God explicitly commands repentance universally.

Repentance is not an optional emotional experience.

It is commanded.

The gospel confronts man not merely with his need for forgiveness but with the necessity of turning away from sin.

Repentance says:

I cannot continue walking away from God while claiming that I have come to God.

IX. SERMON MAIN POINT 4 — CONFESS HIS NAME

Jesus declared in Matthew 10:32:

“Whosoever therefore shall confess me before men, him will I confess also before my Father...”

1. **Context — DC:** Jesus instructs His disciples concerning openly acknowledging Him despite opposition and persecution.
2. **Authority — C:** Christ requires His followers to confess Him before men.

Romans 10:9 speaks of confessing:

“the Lord Jesus.”

1. **Context — DC:** Paul describes the believing and confessing response to the proclaimed word of faith centered upon the risen Lord.
2. **Authority — I:** Genuine faith in Christ is openly expressed through acknowledgment of His lordship.

The confession is fundamentally about **who Jesus is**.

It is not merely repeating a ceremonial sentence.

The convert openly acknowledges allegiance to Jesus Christ.

The confession declares:

Jesus is the Christ.

Jesus is the Son of God.

Jesus is Lord.

Confession makes inward faith outwardly acknowledged.

X. SERMON MAIN POINT 5 — BE BAPTIZED INTO CHRIST

This point requires especially careful biblical language.

Baptism must not be preached as though water possesses saving power independently of Christ.

Neither may baptism be reduced to a symbol performed because salvation has already been completed.

The New Testament repeatedly associates baptism with entrance into Christ and participation in His saving work.

A. Baptized into Christ

Galatians 3:27:

“as many of you as have been baptized into Christ have put on Christ.”

1. **Context — DC:** Paul explains the believer's relationship to Christ, sonship, and unity in the surrounding argument concerning faith.
2. **Authority — I:** Baptism is described directionally as being “into Christ” and is associated with putting on Christ.

Romans 6:3:

“so many of us as were baptized into Jesus Christ were baptized into his death.”

1. **Context — DC:** Paul answers the objection that grace permits continued sin by reminding Christians of what occurred in their conversion.
2. **Authority — I:** Baptism is explicitly described as entrance into Christ and into His death.

The direction is:

into Christ.

B. Baptized into His Death

Romans 6 creates perhaps the strongest theological picture of baptism.

Christ:

Died → Was buried → Was raised.

The believer:

Dies to sin → Is buried in baptism → Rises to walk in newness of life.

Romans 6:4:

“we are buried with him by baptism into death...”

and:

“we also should walk in newness of life.”

1. **Context — DC:** Paul uses baptism to explain why Christians cannot continue living in sin.
2. **Authority — I:** Baptism corresponds to burial with Christ and is followed by a new manner of life patterned after resurrection.
3. **Context — RC:** Colossians 2:12 similarly describes believers as “buried with him in baptism” and raised through faith in God's working.

Baptism therefore reenacts the gospel pattern itself.

C. Baptism and Forgiveness

Acts 2:38:

“Repent, and be baptized... for the remission of sins.”

1. **Context — DC:** Peter answers convicted gospel hearers concerning their required response.
2. **Authority — C:** Repentance and baptism are explicitly commanded.
3. **Context — RC:** Luke 24:47 anticipates repentance and remission being preached in Christ's name beginning at Jerusalem.

Acts 22:16:

“arise, and be baptized, and wash away thy sins...”

1. **Context — DC:** Ananias instructs Saul concerning his required response after his encounter with Christ.
2. **Authority — C:** Baptism is explicitly commanded.
3. **Authority — I:** Baptism is textually associated with the washing away of sins rather than merely a later testimony that forgiveness had already occurred.

1 Peter 3:21:

“The like figure whereunto even baptism doth also now save us...”

1. **Context — DC:** Peter draws a correspondence between salvation through water in Noah's day and Christian baptism.

2. **Authority — I:** Peter explicitly associates baptism with salvation while immediately defining its significance so that the statement cannot be reduced to physical washing.

Peter immediately prevents a materialistic misunderstanding:

“not the putting away of the filth of the flesh...”

1. **Context — DC:** Peter qualifies his statement concerning baptism's saving significance.
2. **Authority — I:** Baptism's significance is spiritual and Christ-centered rather than the physical cleansing power of water.

The power is not ordinary water washing dirt from skin.

Its significance rests in God's saving work through the resurrection of Christ.

Thus:

Christ saves.

His blood saves.

Grace saves.

Faith saves.

The gospel saves.

Baptism saves.

These statements are not contradictions when Scripture is allowed to define their relationship.

They describe different aspects of God's one saving work.

XI. SERMON MAIN POINT 6 — OBEY HIM FAITHFULLY

This point protects the sermon from terminating Christianity at baptism.

Matthew 28:20:

“Teaching them to observe all things whatsoever I have commanded you.”

1. **Context — DC:** Christ requires continued instruction and observance among those made disciples and baptized.
2. **Authority — C:** Disciples are commanded to observe Christ's teaching.

3. **Authority — I:** Christian responsibility continues after baptism.

Acts 2:42:

“they continued stedfastly...”

1. **Context — DC:** Luke describes the continuing life of the newly converted Jerusalem church.
2. **Authority — E:** The first converts provide an inspired example of steadfast Christian practice after baptism.

Revelation 2:10:

“be thou faithful unto death...”

1. **Context — DC:** Christ exhorts suffering Christians in Smyrna to remain faithful despite persecution.
2. **Authority — C:** Faithfulness is commanded even to the point of death.
3. **Context — TC:** The requirement of persevering faithfulness accords with Matthew 24:13; John 15:4–10; Acts 14:22; 1 Corinthians 15:58; Hebrews 3:12–14; 10:35–39; James 1:12; 2 Peter 1:5–11; Revelation 14:12–13.
4. **Authority — I:** Conversion begins a life requiring perseverance rather than guaranteeing that subsequent faithfulness is irrelevant.

Hebrews 5:9 describes Christ as:

“the author of eternal salvation unto all them that obey him.”

1. **Context — DC:** The writer connects Christ's perfected high-priestly work with eternal salvation.
2. **Authority — I:** Obedience is not foreign to saving faith; Scripture expressly describes the recipients of Christ's eternal salvation as those who obey Him.
3. **Context — TC:** The relationship of faith and obedience is reflected throughout Scripture in Genesis 22:15–18; Deuteronomy 30:15–20; Matthew 7:21–27; John 14:15; Romans 1:5; 6:16–18; James 2:14–26; 1 John 2:3–6; Revelation 22:14.

The Christian life is therefore not:

Saved → finished.

It is:

Saved → transformed → serving → growing → enduring → faithful unto death.

Obedience does not purchase salvation.

Obedience demonstrates continued submission to the Savior.

XII. DC / RC / TC HERMENEUTICAL SYNTHESIS

Direct Context — DC

Each salvation passage must first be allowed to speak within its immediate setting.

Acts 2 addresses convicted hearers after the first Pentecost gospel sermon.

Acts 8 records gospel expansion into Samaria and to the Ethiopian.

Acts 10 records Gentile inclusion.

Acts 16 records Lydia and the jailer.

Romans 6 explains the theological meaning of union with Christ.

No verse should first be forced into a predetermined systematic formula.

Remote Context — RC

Related texts illuminate one another.

Luke 24:47 anticipates Acts 2:38.

Matthew 28:19–20 connects baptism with discipleship and continued teaching.

Mark 16:15–16 connects gospel proclamation, belief, baptism, and salvation.

Romans 6 explains what baptism into Christ means.

Galatians 3:27 confirms baptism “into Christ.”

1 Peter 3:21 connects baptism with salvation through Christ's resurrection.

Total Context — TC

The total biblical testimony establishes that:

Salvation originates in God's grace.

Genesis 3:15; 12:1–3; Isaiah 53:4–6; John 3:16–17; Romans 3:23–26; 5:6–10; Ephesians 2:4–10; Titus 2:11–14; 3:4–7; Revelation 7:9–10.

Salvation is accomplished through Christ.

Genesis 22:8, 13–18; Isaiah 53:5–12; Matthew 1:21; John 1:29; Acts 4:10–12; Romans 5:6–11; 1 Corinthians 15:1–4; Hebrews 9:11–15, 26–28; 1 Peter 1:18–21; Revelation 5:9–10.

Salvation is proclaimed through the gospel.

Isaiah 52:7; 61:1; Matthew 28:18–20; Mark 16:15–16; Luke 24:46–47; Romans 1:16; 10:13–17; 1 Corinthians 1:18–24; 15:1–4.

The gospel must be heard.

Isaiah 55:3; Matthew 13:9, 23; Acts 2:37; 8:5–6; 16:14; 18:8; Romans 10:14–17; Revelation 2:7.

Christ must be believed.

Habakkuk 2:4; John 3:16–18; 8:24; Acts 8:12; 16:31–34; Romans 1:16–17; 5:1; Hebrews 10:38–39; 11:1–6.

Sin must be repented of.

Ezekiel 18:30–32; Matthew 3:2; Luke 13:3; 24:47; Acts 2:38; 3:19; 17:30–31; 26:20; 2 Corinthians 7:9–10; 2 Peter 3:9.

Christ must be confessed.

Matthew 10:32–33; 16:15–17; Acts 8:35–38; Romans 10:9–10; Philippians 2:9–11; 1 Timothy 6:12–13; 1 John 4:15.

The believer must be baptized into Christ.

Matthew 28:19; Mark 16:16; Acts 2:38–41; 8:12, 35–39; 10:47–48; 16:14–15, 30–34; 18:8; 19:1–5; 22:16; Romans 6:3–4; Galatians 3:27; Colossians 2:12; 1 Peter 3:21.

The Christian must continue faithfully with Christ.

Ezekiel 18:24; Matthew 10:22; 24:13; John 8:31; 15:4–10; Acts 2:42; 14:21–22; Romans 6:16–18; 1 Corinthians 15:58; Galatians 5:7; Hebrews 3:12–14; 10:35–39; James 1:12; 2 Peter 1:5–11; Revelation 2:10; 14:12–13.

No individual passage should be used to erase another.

The whole counsel of God supplies the whole picture.

XIII. CEI — AUTHORITY ANALYSIS

Command

Scripture explicitly commands:

- **Repent** — Acts 2:38; 17:30.
- **Believe** — John 8:24; Acts 16:31.
- **Be baptized** — Acts 2:38; 10:48.
- **Confess Christ** — Matthew 10:32; Romans 10:9–10.
- **Continue in obedience** — Matthew 28:20; Revelation 2:10.

Example

Inspired conversion narratives repeatedly demonstrate people:

- hearing the gospel,
- believing Christ,
- turning toward God,
- being baptized immediately,
- entering Christian discipleship.

Necessary Inference

Several necessary conclusions follow from the combined evidence.

If faith comes by hearing, the gospel must be communicated before biblical faith can exist.

If Philip “preached Jesus” and the eunuch consequently requested baptism, teaching Jesus included instruction concerning baptism.

If believers were consistently baptized immediately upon accepting the gospel, baptism was not treated by the apostles as an optional later church ceremony.

If baptized disciples were then taught continued obedience, baptism marks a beginning rather than the completion of discipleship.

XIV. THE CENTRAL THEOLOGICAL DISTINCTION

The Plan of Salvation must never be preached as:

“Here are six things you do to save yourself.”

The biblical message is:

God has acted to save you through Jesus Christ. Here is the response He commands you to make to His gospel.

That preserves both truths:

Grace

“For by grace are ye saved...”

— Ephesians 2:8

1. **Context — DC:** Paul grounds salvation in God's gracious action toward those formerly dead in sin.
2. **Authority — I:** Human obedience cannot be interpreted as meritoriously purchasing what Scripture identifies as God's gift.

Obedient Faith

“the obedience of faith”

— Romans 1:5

1. **Context — DC:** Paul describes his apostolic mission as bringing about the obedience of faith among the nations.
2. **Context — RC:** Romans 16:25–26 closes the epistle with the same concept, connecting the revealed gospel with “obedience of faith.”
3. **Authority — I:** Paul does not construct faith and obedience as theological opposites; obedient faith belongs to the purpose of gospel proclamation.

The two are not enemies.

Biblical faith submits to the grace of God.

XV. CONCLUSION — WHAT WILL YOU DO WITH JESUS?

The question is ultimately not:

Do you know the six steps?

One may memorize six steps and never surrender to Christ.

The question is:

What will you do with Jesus?

God has spoken.

Will you hear His Word?

God has revealed His Son.

Will you believe Him?

God has exposed your sin.

Will you repent?

God has declared Jesus Lord.

Will you confess His name?

Christ died, was buried, and arose.

Will you be buried with Him in baptism and rise to walk in newness of life?

Christ calls you to discipleship.

Will you obey Him faithfully?

The plan is not man's invention.

The Savior is not man's provision.

The terms are not man's conditions to rewrite.

God provided the grace.

Christ provided the blood.

The Spirit revealed the Word.

The gospel provides the message.

And now the gospel calls for a response:

Hear His Word.

Believe His Son.

Repent of Sin.

Confess His Name.

Be Baptized into Christ.

Obey Him Faithfully.

The gospel begins with what **God has done for man.**

The invitation ends with the question:

What will you do with Jesus?